

Bartleby, the Scrivener

Herman Melville · 1853

First published: Putnam's Monthly, Nov–Dec 1853

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Cambridge International edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Gustave Caillebotte, Paris Street; Rainy Day (1877). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Piazza_Tales/Bartleby_the_Scrivener (revision 12985183), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about passive resistance?
- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about alienation in modern work?
- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about charity and responsibility?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Cambridge International

CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5

Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Bartleby, the Scrivener	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*passive resistance* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Bartleby, the Scrivener

Author biography

Herman Melville was born in New York City on 1 August 1819. After his merchant father's bankruptcy and death he went to sea, sailing on a whaler in 1841 and jumping ship in the Marquesas; his South Seas adventures Typee (1846) and Omoo (1847) were popular. Moby-Dick (1851) and the works that followed sold poorly, and from 1866 he worked for nineteen years as a customs inspector in New York. He died on 28 September 1891, largely forgotten; his reputation was revived in the 1920s.

Historical and cultural context

Wall Street in the 1840s–50s was becoming the centre of American finance. Before photocopiers and typewriters, legal documents were copied by hand by scriveners (copyists) paid by the page. Melville wrote the story after the commercial failure of Moby-Dick (1851) and Pierre (1852), when he himself was being asked to write what the market wanted.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published anonymously in two parts in Putnam's Monthly Magazine, November and December 1853, as "Bartleby, the Scrivener. A Story of Wall-Street"; collected in The Piazza Tales (1856).

Then: Modestly noticed; Melville's reputation was in decline and he died in 1891 largely forgotten.

Now: Since the Melville revival of the 1920s it has been one of the most discussed American stories; "I would prefer not to" has become a catchphrase for passive resistance, cited in discussions of the Occupy Wall Street movement (2011).

Overview (spoiler-free)

An elderly Wall Street lawyer narrates his encounter with Bartleby, a quiet copyist he hires, who one day begins answering every request with "I would prefer not to."

Main themes

- alienation and work.
- passive resistance.
- charity and its limits.

Why it matters

The story speaks to modern experiences of meaningless work, burnout and the limits of compassion.

Spoilers · teacher only

Bartleby stops working entirely and refuses to leave; the lawyer moves his office rather than evict him. Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer then hears a rumour that Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open Bartleby, the Scrivener: Have you ever wanted to just say no to a task without explaining why?
Prompt: Before we open Bartleby, the Scrivener: Have you ever wanted to just say no to a task without explaining why?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

unreliable narrator; passive resistance; alienation; scrivener; characterization.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Herman Melville was born in New York City on 1 August 1819. After his merchant father's bankruptcy and death he went to sea, sailing on a whaler in 1841 and jumping ship in the Marquesas; his South Seas adventures Typee (1846) and Omoo (1847) were popular. Moby-Dick (1851) and the works that followed sold poorly, and from 1866 he worked for nineteen years as a customs inspector in New York. He died on 28 September 1891, largely forgotten; his reputation was revived in the 1920s. The world of the book. Wall Street in the 1840s–50s was becoming the centre of American finance. Before photocopiers and typewriters, legal documents were copied by hand by scriveners (copyists) paid by the page. Melville wrote the story after the commercial failure of Moby-Dick (1851) and Pierre (1852), when he himself was being asked to write what the market wanted. Publication and reception. First published anonymously in two parts in Putnam's Monthly Magazine, November and December 1853, as "Bartleby, the Scrivener. A Story of Wall-Street"; collected in The Piazza Tales (1856). Then: Modestly noticed; Melville's reputation was in decline and he died in 1891 largely forgotten. Now: Since the Melville revival of the 1920s it has been one of the most discussed American stories; "I would prefer not to" has become a catchphrase for passive resistance, cited in discussions of the Occupy Wall Street movement (2011).

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51). Bartleby's refrain.

> *I would prefer not to* *(Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51)*

Think-aloud: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51). Bartleby's refrain.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): An elderly Wall Street lawyer narrates his encounter with Bartleby, a quiet copyist he hires, who one day begins answering every request with "I would prefer not to." Themes to track: alienation and work.: passive resistance.: charity and its limits.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for Bartleby, the Scrivener: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does Bartleby, the Scrivener still matter? The story speaks to modern experiences of meaningless work, burnout and the limits of compassion.
Anchor question: Why might Bartleby, the Scrivener still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story speaks to modern experiences of meaningless work, burnout and the limits of compassion.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does the lawyer keep trying to help Bartleby? Answer: Pity, guilt, a sense of shared humanity, and perhaps self-image as a charitable man.
Exit ticket: Why does the lawyer keep trying to help Bartleby?
Answer: Pity, guilt, a sense of shared humanity, and perhaps self-image as a charitable man.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: Bartleby, the Scrivener.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Herman Melville" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Herman-Melville); The Melville Society (https://melvillesociety.org/); Melville Society, Melville's works (https://melvillesociety.org/); Library of America, Melville: Pierre, Israel Potter, The Piazza Tales (https://www.loa.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Links to Occupy Wall Street are a cultural reference, not part of the story's original reception.

Lesson 2: Bartleby, the Scrivener

Focus: refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

Objective: Students will analyze how point of view develops in “Bartleby, the Scrivener” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (death in prison): Sensitive content: Death in prison. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death in prison.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer learns Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office: 'Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity!'

Background: Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand.

Significance: Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to alienation and work because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes death in prison.
Prompt: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to alienation and work because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: cistern — a tank for storing water; benevolently — in a kind, well-meaning way; chimeras — wild, impossible dreams or fantasies; obtruded — pushed forward unwelcome; invocation — a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service. "obtruded": From Latin obtrūdō "thrust off or against", from ob- "ob-" + trūdō "thrust". "invocation": From Middle English invocacioun, from Old French invocacion, from Latin invocatio, invocationem. Equivalent to invoke + -ation.
Words: cistern: a tank for storing water · benevolently: in a kind, well-meaning way · chimeras: wild, impossible dreams or fantasies · obtruded: pushed forward unwelcome · invocation: a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand. Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central. Narrator: The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby. Setting: The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life. Repetition: "I would prefer not to" becomes almost comic, then tragic. Watch for walls and dead letters: blocked communication and lost lives.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I would prefer not to" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51). The refrain. That is narrator at work: The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.

> *I would prefer not to* *(Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I would prefer not to" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51). The refrain. That is narrator at work: The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Pairing Bartleby with "humanity" makes him a representative of everyone. Ask: How does this line connect to alienation and work? Expected: Copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. (The last line.)

> *Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity* *(Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Pairing Bartleby with "humanity" makes him a representative of everyone.
Ask: How does this line connect to alienation and work?
Expected answer: Copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. (The last line.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for narrator, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. When the text says “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485), it shows this directly. Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

Task: Annotate the story for narrator, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. When the text says “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485), it shows this directly. Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses? Ask: is Bartleby's refusal resistance or illness?

Anchor question: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?

Facilitation: Ask: is Bartleby's refusal resistance or illness?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. (“Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men”, Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. (“Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men”, Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how narrator shapes refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Key takeaway: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Narrator:** The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.
- **Setting:** The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life.
- **Repetition:** "I would prefer not to" becomes almost comic, then tragic.

Themes and how they develop

- **alienation and work:** copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

Symbols and motifs

- **walls and dead letters:** blocked communication and lost lives.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) The refrain.
- “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) The lawyer's reflection.
- “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486) The last line.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition.
Evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485)
Reasoning: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cistern (noun)	a tank for storing water	*Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and*	

		mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.	
benevolently (adverb)	in a kind, well-meaning way	*At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.*	
chimeras (noun)	wild, impossible dreams or fantasies	*These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.*	
obtruded (verb)	pushed forward unwelcome	*I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remarks obtruded upon me by my professional friends who visited the rooms.*	"obtruded": From Latin obtrūdō "thrust off or against", from ob- "ob-" + trūdō "thrust". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/obtrude#Etymology)
invocation (noun)	a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service	*Like a very ghost, agreeably to the laws of magical invocation, at the*	"invocation": From Middle English invocacioun, from Old French invocacion, from Latin invocatio, invocationem. Equivalent to invoke + -ation. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/invocation#Etymology)
unexampled (adjective)	never seen before; unequaled	*Instantly it occurred to me, that his unexampled diligence in*	
interment (noun)	the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave	*Imagination will readily supply the meager recital of poor Bartleby's interment.*	"interment": From Old French enterrement "burial," from enterrer "to put in the earth" (Latin terra "earth"). (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/interment)
heighten (verb)	to increase	*Conceive a man by nature and misfortune prone to a pallid hopelessness, can any business seem more fitted to heighten it than that of continually handling these dead letters, and assorting them for the flames?*	"heighten": From Middle English heightenen, hyghtenen, equivalent to height + en. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/heighten#Etymology)
surmises (noun)	guesses	*Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other*	"surmises": From Old French surmis, past participle of surmetre, surmettre "to accuse", from sur- "upon" + metre "to

		respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man.	put". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/surmise#Etymology)
penniless (adjective)	not having enough money to pay for necessities	*myself to be ignominiously repulsed by this lean, penniless wight?—my*	“penniless”: From Middle English penyles, penylees; equivalent to penny + less. Compare Old Norse penningalauss "penniless". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/penniless#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with passive resistance?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the narrator's profession? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: A Wall Street lawyer
2. What is Bartleby's job? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Scrivener, or copyist
3. What is Bartleby's famous reply? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: I would prefer not to
4. What does the narrator finally do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Moves his offices away
5. Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: The Dead Letter Office
6. Retell the three most important events of “Bartleby, the Scrivener” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer learns Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office:…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.

8. Where and when does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.” What does “cistern” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: cistern: a tank for storing water.
10. Reread: “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.” What does “benevolently” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: benevolently: in a kind, well-meaning way.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects,…”, why might Melville have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison,…
6. As the opening story, what does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” set up that the rest of Bartleby, the Scrivener will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with passive resistance? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. On setting: The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of “Bartleby, the Scrivener” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Bartleby, the Scrivener”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to alienation in modern work: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Melville need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “Bartleby, the Scrivener” treats refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Bartleby, the Scrivener see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve passive resistance? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a

wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Herman Melville about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Like a very ghost, agreeably to the laws of magical _____, at the” Word bank: cistern, benevolently, chimeras, invocation
   Key: invocation
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Imagination will readily supply the meager recital of poor Bartleby's _____.” Word bank: cistern, benevolently, interment, chimeras
   Key: interment
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor?
   A. A bank
   B. A ship
   C. A prison
   D. The Dead Letter Office
   Key: D (The Dead Letter Office)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Bartleby's famous reply?
   A. I cannot
   B. I would prefer not to

C. Leave me alone

D. Not today

Key: B (I would prefer not to)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Conceive a man by nature and misfortune prone to a pallid hopelessness, can any business seem more fitted to _____ it than that of continually handling these dead letters, and assorting them for the flames?” Word bank: cistern, heighten, benevolently, chimeras

   Key: heighten

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Bartleby's job?

   A. Clerk in a shop

   B. Scrivener, or copyist

   C. Accountant

   D. Messenger

   Key: B (Scrivener, or copyist)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the narrator's profession?

   A. A doctor

   B. A banker

   C. A Wall Street lawyer

   D. A judge

   Key: C (A Wall Street lawyer)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the narrator finally do?

   A. Fires everyone

   B. Pays Bartleby to leave

   C. Calls the police at once

   D. Moves his offices away

   Key: D (Moves his offices away)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485: “Dead _____! does it not sound like dead men”

   Key: letters

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Instantly it occurred to me, that his _____ diligence in” Word bank: benevolently, chimeras, cistern, unexampled

    Key: unexampled

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Bartleby, the Scrivener”?

    A. Endurance turning to justice

    B. The futile attempt to shut out death

    C. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

    D. Science that poisons love

    Key: C (Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The lawyer's reflection.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The refrain.
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life.
    A. Diction / vocabulary
    B. Setting
    C. Personification
    D. Structure

    Key: B (Setting)
15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.
    A. Metaphor
    B. Symbolism
    C. Narrator
    D. Point of view

    Key: C (Narrator)
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The lawyer's reflection.
17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The last line.
18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485).
    Sample answer: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how alienation and work develops from an earlier story to “Bartleby, the Scrivener”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The refrain.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remarks obtruded upon me by my professional friends who visited the rooms.”, what does “obtruded” most nearly mean?

    A. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    B. pushed forward unwelcome

    C. in a kind, well-meaning way

    D. a tank for storing water

    Key: B (pushed forward unwelcome)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.”, what does “cistern” most nearly mean?

    A. in a kind, well-meaning way

    B. pushed forward unwelcome

    C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    D. a tank for storing water

    Key: D (a tank for storing water)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.”, what does “chimeras” most nearly mean?

    A. in a kind, well-meaning way

    B. a tank for storing water

    C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    D. pushed forward unwelcome

    Key: C (wild, impossible dreams or fantasies)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.”, what does “benevolently” most nearly mean?

    A. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    B. in a kind, well-meaning way

    C. a tank for storing water

    D. pushed forward unwelcome

    Key: B (in a kind, well-meaning way)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 6, 9, 5, 4, 7, 10, 2, 3, 12, 13, 11, 17, 18, 15, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	6, 9, 7, 5, 2, 3, 1, 8, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 18, 19, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
		recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2

HS Junior	5, 10, 9, 6, 3, 2, 1, 11, 13, 12, 18, 14, 17, 15, 16, 21	
HS Senior	10, 6, 7, 9, 8, 5, 13, 11, 12, 17, 18, 15, 14, 21, 19, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 9, 2, 22, 5, 12, 13, 11, 14, 18, 15, 17, 16, 19, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 1, 4, 3, 23, 12, 11, 13, 18, 15, 14, 17, 16, 19, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	1, 24, 7, 4, 2, 13, 11, 12, 18, 15, 14, 17, 20, 16, 21, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	24, 2, 6, 1, 9, 11, 12, 13, 14, 17, 18, 15, 20, 21, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	7, 6, 2, 3, 10, 11, 12, 13, 18, 15, 17, 14, 19, 16, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	10, 25, 6, 7, 1, 12, 11, 13, 18, 14, 15, 17, 16, 19, 21, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Bartleby, the Scrivener,” how does Melville show refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): In Bartleby, the Scrivener, how does Melville develop the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Bartleby, the Scrivener suggests about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Herman Melville uses point of view in Bartleby, the Scrivener to complicate the reader's understanding of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Situate Bartleby, the Scrivener within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Read Bartleby, the Scrivener alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Bartleby, the Scrivener and its treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Bartleby, the Scrivener as evidence for a larger claim about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Bartleby, the Scrivener as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Bartleby, the Scrivener.

SAT-style questions

1. *These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “chimeras” most nearly mean?

   A. not having enough money to pay for necessities

   B. to increase

   C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

   D. guesses

2. *Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man. But indeed, nature herself seemed to have been his vintner, and at his birth charged him so thoroughly with an irritable, brandy-like disposition, that all subsequent potations were needless. When I consider how, amid the stillness of my chambers, Nippers would sometimes impatiently rise from his seat, and stooping over his table, spread his arms wide apart, seize the whole desk, and move it, and jerk it, with a grim, grinding motion on the floor, as if the table were a perverse voluntary agent, intent on thwarting and vexing him; I plainly perceive that for Nippers, brandy and water were altogether superfluous.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Bartleby, the Scrivener"?

A. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

B. Science that poisons love

C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

D. A crime that backfires

SAT key: 1. C (wild, impossible dreams or fantasies); 2. A (Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve)

Unit test

Bartleby, the Scrivener: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the narrator finally do?
   A. Fires everyone
   B. Pays Bartleby to leave
   C. Calls the police at once
   D. Moves his offices away

   Key: D (Moves his offices away)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Bartleby's job?
   A. Clerk in a shop
   B. Scrivener, or copyist
   C. Accountant
   D. Messenger

   Key: B (Scrivener, or copyist)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Instantly it occurred to me, that his _____ diligence in” Word bank: benevolently, chimeras, cistern, unexampled

   Key: unexampled
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485: “Dead _____! does it not sound like dead men”

   Key: letters
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the narrator's profession?
   A. A doctor
   B. A banker
   C. A Wall Street lawyer
   D. A judge

   Key: C (A Wall Street lawyer)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Conceive a man by nature and misfortune prone to a pallid hopelessness, can any business seem more fitted to _____ it than that of

continually handling these dead letters, and assorting them for the flames?" Word bank: cistern, heighten, benevolently, chimeras

Key: heighten

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Like a very ghost, agreeably to the laws of magical _____, at the" Word bank: cistern, benevolently, chimeras, invocation

   Key: invocation

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Bartleby's famous reply?

   A. I cannot

   B. I would prefer not to

   C. Leave me alone

   D. Not today

   Key: B (I would prefer not to)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor?

   A. A bank

   B. A ship

   C. A prison

   D. The Dead Letter Office

   Key: D (The Dead Letter Office)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Imagination will readily supply the meager recital of poor Bartleby's _____." Word bank: cistern, benevolently, interment, chimeras

    Key: interment

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "I would prefer not to" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The refrain.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The lawyer's reflection.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Bartleby, the Scrivener"?

    A. Endurance turning to justice

    B. The futile attempt to shut out death

    C. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

    D. Science that poisons love

    Key: C (Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "Bartleby, the Scrivener"? The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Symbolism

    C. Narrator

    D. Point of view

    Key: C (Narrator)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Setting

    C. Personification

    D. Structure

    Key: B (Setting)

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The last line.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485).

    Sample answer: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how alienation and work develops from an earlier story to “Bartleby, the Scrivener”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The lawyer's reflection.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The refrain.

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remarks obtruded upon me by my professional friends who visited the rooms.”, what does “obtruded” most nearly mean?

    A. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    B. pushed forward unwelcome

    C. in a kind, well-meaning way

    D. a tank for storing water

    Key: B (pushed forward unwelcome)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.”, what does “cistern” most nearly mean?

    A. in a kind, well-meaning way

B. pushed forward unwelcome

C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

D. a tank for storing water

Key: D (a tank for storing water)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.”, what does “benevolently” most nearly mean?

A. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

B. in a kind, well-meaning way

C. a tank for storing water

D. pushed forward unwelcome

Key: B (in a kind, well-meaning way)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.”, what does “chimeras” most nearly mean?

A. in a kind, well-meaning way

B. a tank for storing water

C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

D. pushed forward unwelcome

Key: C (wild, impossible dreams or fantasies)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 10, 3, 6, 5, 7, 8, 1, 9, 2, 12, 11, 13, 16, 17, 14, 15, 19	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 4, 3, 5, 10, 6, 9, 1, 7, 8, 12, 11, 13, 15, 14, 16, 19, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 3, 2, 9, 8, 10, 7, 4, 6, 11, 13, 12, 16, 15, 17, 14, 20, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 4, 10, 8, 1, 2, 6, 3, 12, 11, 13, 17, 15, 14, 16, 18, 20, 19	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	7, 22, 1, 23, 3, 24, 9, 11, 12, 13, 16, 17, 14, 15, 20, 21, 18, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	9, 2, 22, 7, 23, 3, 4, 13, 12, 11, 14, 16, 15, 17, 20, 21, 18, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 1, 25, 22, 3, 7, 2, 12, 11, 13, 16, 15, 17, 14, 20, 19, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	1, 10, 9, 3, 23, 5, 7, 12, 13, 11, 14, 15, 17, 16, 20, 19, 18, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Senior	5, 2, 7, 3, 8, 25, 22, 13, 11, 12, 17, 14, 15, 16, 21, 19, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	2, 7, 8, 6, 22, 9, 25, 13, 12, 11, 14, 17, 15, 16, 19, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

Bartleby, the Scrivener: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Herman Melville develops passive resistance across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Bartleby, the Scrivener and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to alienation in modern work.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Bartleby, the Scrivener finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of charity and responsibility. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Passive resistance

Middle School (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about passive resistance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops passive resistance across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of passive resistance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of passive resistance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of passive resistance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four

scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Alienation in modern work

Middle School (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about alienation in modern work. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops alienation in modern work across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of alienation in modern work. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of alienation in modern work, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of alienation in modern work in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Charity and responsibility

Middle School (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about charity and responsibility. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops charity and responsibility across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of charity and responsibility. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of charity and responsibility, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of charity and responsibility in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary or Wiktionary, 2026-10-20); unverified ones are left out. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.